necessary, or was it one more maneuver by Netanyahu to hold his coalition together? Ben-Gvir is ready to join the team, and he has already announced that it was his badgering that compelled Netanyahu to act. I wouldn't be astonished if he were right for once.

In Israel's short history, war has been an integral part of its existence. In most cases, the wars appeared to be vitally necessary; in a few cases they were results of complete misjudgment or, worse, of political maneuvers (the Second Lebanon War is possibly the most striking example). The trouble is that the unavoidably opaque character of Israeli defense policy makes external judgment almost impossible during the events and sometimes for long afterward. In the present case, it is particularly difficult to take a clear view.

The country is possibly getting ready for a significant war, and people have been warned to prepare their air raid shelters. Moreover, there is a massive evacuation of the inhabitants of the Gaza periphery. What is new is that, for the first time, the country will get scant international support. Moreover, a headline in *Haaretz e*xpressed quite correctly what many feel: "In their missions, our pilots will not know whether they are fighting for their country or for the government of Israel." Netanyahu has poisoned the atmosphere to such a point that suspicion is the name of the game.

Wednesday, May 10

Islamic Jihad has reacted with a hail of rockets on central Israel, but without much effect. The situation may either develop into a wider conflict or lead to a truce.

It seems that, notwithstanding the rockets from Gaza, a truce brokered by Egypt is in the making, although the demands of the Palestinians seem difficult to accept. In the meantime, the head of Jihad's rocket command has also been killed.